
The Year of Your Neck and Shoulders

Companion Workbook — map your upper-body
patterns and track your progress

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #2 Workbook

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Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC2 DEEP CUT.
Map your upper-body patterns and track your progress.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

YEAR-LONG REFERENCE. USE THE PATTERN SELF-assessment when something flares. Use the 30-day tracker when starting a new home practice. Use the seasonal check-ins.

Bring it to every session.

CHAPTER 2

Pattern Self-Assessment

USE THIS WHEN NECK OR SHOULDER PAIN SHOWS up.

Right now, my upper body feels:

Pain level (0-10):

- Neck: [____]
- Right shoulder: [____]
- Left shoulder: [____]
- Headaches: [____]

Where exactly?

- [] Both upper traps, both sides of neck
- [] One-sided neck and shoulder — [] Right / [] Left
- [] Deep in the shoulder joint
- [] Base of skull, into temples (headaches)
- [] Down the arm / into the hand (SEE DOCTOR)

Pattern questions

1. When does it hurt most?

- [] Progressively through the workday → Pattern 1 (Desk Worker Hunch)
- [] During stressful periods → Pattern 2 (Tension Storage)
- [] Mornings, when waking → Pattern 3 (Sleep Position Damage)
- [] Specific movements (overhead, behind back) → Pattern 4 (Rotator Cuff)
- [] All the time, mostly stiff, getting worse over weeks → Pattern 5 (Frozen Shoulder)

2. Have you lost range of motion?

- [] No, just pain
- [] Yes, progressively over weeks (POSSIBLE FROZEN SHOULDER — see doctor)
- [] Yes, but only with one specific movement (overhead reaching)

3. Does it refer down the arm?

- [] Stays in neck/shoulder
- [] Numbness or tingling into the arm or hand (SEE DOCTOR)
- [] Refers into headache pattern

4. My best guess at which pattern:

5. Specific intervention I'll try first:

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: WHEN IN YOUR DAY ARE YOUR shoulders highest (closest to your ears)? Map the trigger — Zoom calls, certain people, financial conversations, traffic, etc.

Prompt 2: Describe your sleep position and pillow. Have you ever woken up with a “crick” in your neck that took days to resolve? What was different that night?

Prompt 3: What's your relationship with your phone in terms of head position? Estimate hours per day with your head tilted forward looking at a screen.

CHAPTER 4

30-Day Upper-Body Tracker

USE WHEN STARTING A NEW HOME PRACTICE.

Daily check pattern

- Daily routine done? (Y/N)
 - Neck pain AM / PM (0-10)
 - Shoulder pain AM / PM (0-10)
 - Headaches today? (count)
 - One word for how upper body feels
-

Week 1

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	NECK AM	NECK PM	SHOULDER AM	SHOULDER PM
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						

Week 2

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	NECK AM	NECK PM	SHOULDER AM	SHOULDER PM
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						

Week 3

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	NECK AM	NECK PM	SHOULDER AM	SHOULDER PM
15						
16						
17						
18						
19						
20						
21						

Week 4

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	NECK AM	NECK PM	SHOULDER AM	SHOULDER PM
22						
23						
24						
25						
26						
27						
28						
29						
30						

CHAPTER 5

30-Day Reflection

AVERAGE NECK PAIN (DAYS 1-7 VS 24-30): _ →

Average shoulder pain (Days 1-7 vs 24-30): _ →

Total headaches in the 30 days: _ (compared to last month: __)

Number of days I did the routine: _____ out of 30

Most common trigger that made things worse:

What's the biggest change?

What still needs work?

CHAPTER 6

Seasonal Check-Ins

Spring Check-In

DATE: ____

Tax season stress level (0-10): [__]

Yard work activation plan:

Summer Check-In

Date: ____

AC exposure during work hours: hours per day:

Bonus 6 (AC reset) protocol commitment: []
Yes / [] No

Hot shower nightly? [] Yes / [] No

Fall Check-In

Date: ____

Cumulative summer load (0-10): [__]

Fall recovery commitment:

Hunting season this fall? [☐] Yes — pre-hunt warm-up commitment: ____ / [☐] No

Winter Check-In

Date: ____

Morning stiffness baseline (0-10): [__]

Holiday stress level (0-10): [__]

Bonus 11 (Holiday Stress Body Scan) commitment: ____ times per week

CHAPTER 7

Sleep Position Audit (do this once when reading this workbook)

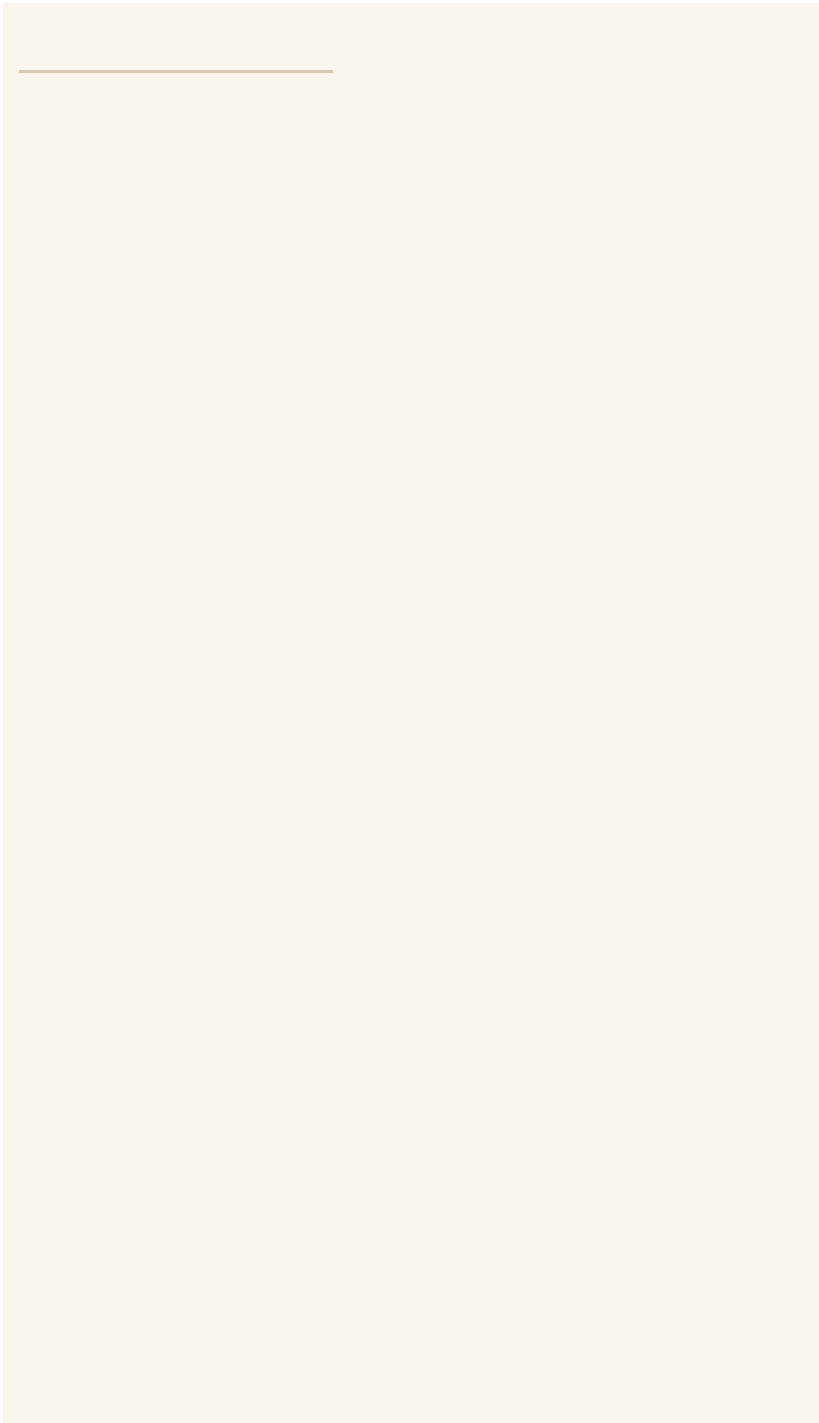
CURRENT SLEEP POSITION: ☐ SIDE / ☐ BACK /
☐ Stomach / ☐ Combination

Current pillow: ☐ Memory foam / ☐ Down / ☐ Polyfill / ☐ Cervical pillow / ☐ Other: _

Side-sleeper check: When you lie on your side, is your head in line with your spine? ☐ Yes / ☐ Tips down / ☐ Tips up

Action needed:

- ☐ Pillow is right — keep it
- ☐ Pillow too thin — add second pillow or replace with thicker
- ☐ Pillow too thick — replace with thinner or fold over
- ☐ Consider switching from stomach sleeping (if applicable)
- ☐ Try cervical pillow if standard pillow doesn't work



CHAPTER 8

Year-End Upper-Body Inventory

COMPARED TO JANUARY, MY NECK AND
shoulders are: ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

Headache frequency: ☐ Less than January / ☐ Same / ☐ More

Range of motion (rotation, reaching overhead): ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

Sleep quality (related to neck): ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

One thing I'll commit to for next year:

CHAPTER 9

Try this for 30 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Doorframe stretch. Three times a day. 30 seconds each. Every day for 30 days.

That's 90 seconds a day total. Three brief visits to any doorframe in your house.

If your neck and shoulders have been chronically tight and you do just this one stretch consistently for 30 days, the change is often dramatic. Most people see real difference by day 10-14.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
Nate.